

Project PrEP Dialogues

Audiences

In your cluster, your audiences are important influencers, including community leaders and stakeholders, parents, guardians and caregivers, adolescent girls and young women, and their male peers and partners.

Purpose (objectives) of dialogues:

1. To have a conversation with community members (whether they are parents, young people or other influential stakeholders like pastors or teachers) and remind them that HIV, STIs and unintended pregnancies are still issues affecting the health and well-being of young women.
2. To provide information about all the services Project PrEP offers, especially oral PrEP.
3. To mobilise community members to support young women to access healthcare services and continue with HIV prevention and contraception for as long as they need it.

We want the people in your cluster to be proud of the fact that Wits RHI and Project PrEP are part of their community.

THESE CARDS ARE FOR DIALOGUES ONLY, health talk cue cards are different.

Welcome and introduction!



- As people arrive at the dialogue venue, please welcome them individually and ask them to enter and take a seat.
- Once it is time to start the dialogue, the cluster manager will officially welcome everyone and may ask a volunteer to say a prayer - if appropriate, thereafter:
 - Please acknowledge the audience, i.e. It is wonderful to see so many of our traditional leaders here today OR your attendance at this meeting is important and appreciated.
 - Introduce all the Project PrEP team members in the room.

Project PrEP / Wits RHI: Who are we?



health

Department:
Health
REPUBLIC OF SOUTH AFRICA

Project PrEP is part of an organisation called Wits RHI, and we work closely with South Africa's National Department of Health (NDOH). In this clinic (or from our mobile clinic), we provide contraception, HIV prevention, and STI screening and treatment to girls and young women. We also provide oral PREP!

But first, let's take a step back and talk about PrEP! PrEP is a type of medication that an HIV-negative person can take to PREVENT HIV. This means that if a person is HIV-negative, they can take this medication, and if they ever come into contact with the virus, they will most likely NOT be infected.

Girls and young women and HIV



Before we go further, I first want to ask whether anyone knows how many adolescent girls and young women are newly infected with HIV every week in South Africa?



Answer: Almost 2 000 adolescent girls and young women are infected with the virus every week in South Africa.



- This means, HIV is still a real public health crisis in South Africa.
- We know that we cannot stop the spread of new infections without prevention and without you!
- We also know that unintended pregnancies, HIV and some STIs still affect many people, and all the research shows that girls and young women are the most affected.

Girls and young women and HIV (Continued)

So why are our girls and young women so very affected by HIV, pregnancy and STIs?

First, we have to understand that young women are not having sex all by themselves... girls and young women who get pregnant or perhaps have an STI do not find themselves in that position without a partner or man. So often, we hear that girls and young women who are pregnant or living with HIV “simply can’t control themselves or don’t have morals,” but this is NOT TRUE.

Girls and young women and HIV (Continued)

We need to ask ourselves, what can we do, all of us, to ensure our young people grow up without HIV, other STIs and unintended pregnancies?

- Many young people do not have enough knowledge about HIV and sexual and reproductive health, that is, HOW to prevent pregnancy, HIV and STIs, and WHY!
- Young women don't always know that they are 4 times more likely to get HIV than their male friends or partners.
- And that if a person starts having sex when they are very young, they are also more likely to get HIV or an STI.

A lot of research has been done on this over the past years, in South Africa, Africa and the world and we now know without a doubt that when we educate our young people about safe sex, not only do they feel confident enough to have safe sex BUT they also feel more comfortable to only start having sex at a later stage in their lives.

Girls and young women and HIV (Continued)

We also know and understand that the girls and young women who are the most affected by HIV are:

- Young women who have no other choice than to engage in transactional sex to ensure they have the basics to get on with life, like taxi money to get to school or even just money for food and toiletries.
- Young women who might also be in a relationship where they are being abused or where they are not respected if they do NOT want to have sex.
- Young women who have more than one partner, for whatever reason.
- Young women who are scared to go to a clinic or need permission to go to a clinic, these young women often times feel so stigmatized that they don't visit a clinic for support.

For each of these reasons, we have an opportunity to come together to support girls and young women. It is our duty to educate young people and to have conversations with them about sex that are non-judgmental but rather supportive. We not only have to make sure that the girls and young women in our lives know that they are allowed to go to a clinic; we should also go with them and support them.

Oral PrEP

Oral PrEP: Oral PrEP is a daily pill that a person takes to prevent HIV infection. But you don't have to take it for the rest of your life, only when you are most worried about HIV.

- It works really well! It is **more than 90% successful** at preventing HIV.
- If you don't want people to know that you are using PrEP, **you can hide the pills** - it's your choice whether you tell people you are using PrEP or not.
- This method prevents HIV **all over your body**; it doesn't matter if you are having vaginal sex, anal sex, maybe injecting drugs and sharing needles or being exposed to blood.
- And, people who are **pregnant or breastfeeding** can use it too. It is safe for you and your baby.
- It is also a great HIV prevention method for people whose **partner is living with HIV**.
- Oral PrEP has some **side effects**, just like every medication has some side effects, even Disprin or Panado! Some people, about 2 out of every 10 people, report that they might get a bad headache, or perhaps feel a bit tired, maybe even feel somewhat nauseous or experience a bit of diarrhoea. This does not happen to everyone, and these side effects will go away. Your nurse will also help you to overcome these side effects, you are not alone!

What does PrEP not do?



- Oral PrEP does not prevent other STIs or pregnancy; you can, however, use it with any other medication and with your family planning.
- And, **PrEP is NOT PEP!** It will not work if you take or use it after you've come into contact with HIV, like when the condom bursts or you forget to use a condom.



So, what do you have to do if you want to start oral PrEP?

- Test negative for HIV. You may also have to let the nurse draw some blood to ensure you have no other conditions that you might not even know about. Then our professional nurse will explain the medication and the process to you before you get your first container of PrEP pills.

Where does Project PrEP provide services?

Project PrEP provides services in clinics, through mobile clinics in communities, at tertiary institutions, schools and colleges. You can ask any of us for more details or...



Send us a WhatsApp message on 065 869 8031.

We are always trying to find more ways to make services available to anyone who needs them; some people can't visit a clinic, or even get to our mobile clinics. So, we are trying to look at new places in this area that will be convenient for people, like:

- Local Pharmacies like Dischem/ Clicks
- Community-Based Organisations
- Colleges, universities and TVETs
- Churches and community halls
- And Chief's places in some districts

Project PrEP's research on new methods

- **Remember that oral PrEP (the pills) are available to everyone.**



- In 2023 and 2024, Wits RHI started a research study by providing the PrEP ring and PrEP injection to people who consented to being part of the research study.



- RIGHT NOW, the PrEP ring and PrEP injection are only available to people who are already part of this research study – we are no longer asking new people to join this study. This means, only people who are part of this study can continue with the PrEP ring or PrEP injection, or re-initiate on one of these methods.



This research helps us to find out how people feel about the PrEP ring or PrEP injection and how they want the NDOH and government to provide and promote these methods to people.

VERY IMPORTANT: Remember that when the study ends, you might not be able to get the ring or injection while the study results are being looked at, but you will still be able to get oral PrEP!

Project PrEP is running this study in two provinces in South Africa, in the Eastern Cape and Gauteng.

What have we learned from our research study so far?

From August 2023 to April 2024 (9 months) we offered people a choice between the PrEP ring and oral PrEP... but what exactly did we do?



- In Mthatha, Gqeberha & Tshwane, people had a choice between the PrEP ring and oral PrEP – 2,738 people participated in this study, and 126 women took part in focus group discussions.

What have we learned from our research study so far? (continued)

What did we learn during these 9 months?

- 83.6% of women chose oral PrEP and the other 16.4% chose the PrEP ring. Women told us that they chose a specific method because they either felt it was the safest method to use (68,5%), or because it suited their lifestyle best (36.8%).
- People who chose the PrEP ring preferred it because it was easier to use compared to a daily pill.
- The people in this study also told us that they were eager to use the PrEP methods and take part in the study because of the education they received through pamphlets and materials, the fact that they could look at demonstration PrEP rings, pelvic models that showed them where the PrEP ring would be in their body, and because of our healthcare providers that supported them on their PrEP journey.
- Some people were hesitant to use the PrEP ring and/or oral PrEP because they had concerns about side effects, stigma they might experience, myths about PrEP, whether they would have support to use the methods, and how it would influence their experience at the clinic (health system concerns).

What have we learned from our research study so far? (continued)

The big lessons we learned from these 9 months:

- It is important to offer different PrEP options because not all people are the same, and different people have different HIV prevention needs.
- For people who struggle to take a daily pill for HIV prevention, a long-acting method, like the PrEP ring, can help them overcome this challenge.
- But... when new PrEP methods become available, it is very important that people are supported to use these methods, educated about the methods – people need to know and understand everything about these methods, and the health system (like in public health clinics) has to be supported to provide these new methods.

What have we learned from our research study so far? (continued)

From April 2024 to November 2024 (8 months) we offered people a choice between the oral PrEP, the PrEP ring and the PrEP injection... but what exactly did we do?

- In Mthatha, Gqeberha & Tshwane, people had a choice between these three methods, and 3,784 – people participated in this phase of the study.

What have we learned from our research study so far? (continued)

What did we learn during these 8 months?

- Incredibly, 75% of all the people in this phase of the study chose to initiate on the PrEP injection (CAB-LA); and more than 70% of them came back for their next injection at their month 1 follow-up visit.
- This means that many people are interested in the PrEP injection, and people who use the PrEP injection are very committed to continuing using this PrEP and HIV prevention method, for as long as they need it.
- It also shows that people who use this method, and their communities, are very accepting of the PrEP injection.

You are important – we need your support



I want to acknowledge that having these discussions about HIV, STIs and even contraception can be very difficult. But we would not be here, if it wasn't very important to us to get your insights, experience and your support. We know that we cannot make a difference in the lives of young people (and all people) in this district, if you do not help us.

We now want to stop talking so that we can listen to you! We want to hear from you – what do you think you can do to support this work? What are your concerns, your questions and advice for us?

Thank you!



- We are nearing the end of our discussion today and before we have some refreshments together – we want to thank you for taking the time to be part of this conversation, and for agreeing to support HIV prevention in this community. Please feel free to ask us any other questions during teatime, we are here to listen!

Please feel free to ask us any other questions during teatime, we are here to listen!

- To remind you, you can visit our website www.myprep.co.za for more information or follow us on social media (MyPrEP South Africa).
- We'll have more dialogues like this throughout the year so we can be a constant source of information and support for the community, please let us know if you want to be invited to another dialogue.
- If you see us in the mobile van, come say “hi”. We can only succeed if we have you on our side. We are, because you are.

Go well!